

Date: May 25th, 2026

Week 0: Orientation, Onboarding & Python Readiness

CariSurg Healthcare AI Program

Assignment 4 - Vital Sign Description (Day 4)

Vital Sign: Respiratory Rate (RR)

Respiratory rate (RR) is the number of breaths a person takes per minute and is an important indicator of respiratory and overall physiological function. In healthy adults, a normal respiratory rate is typically between 12 and 20 breaths per minute. A respiratory rate above 20 breaths per minute is known as tachypnoea and may indicate conditions such as respiratory infection, asthma, anxiety, fever, sepsis, or respiratory distress. Conversely, a respiratory rate below 12 breaths per minute is called bradypnoea and may occur in cases of drug overdose, head injury, or neurological impairment. Severe abnormalities in respiratory rate can lead to inadequate oxygen delivery and may become life-threatening if not treated promptly. In triage settings, respiratory rate is especially important because it is often one of the earliest signs of patient deterioration. Triage nurses use respiratory rate measurements to assess the severity of illness, identify patients requiring urgent intervention, and monitor the effectiveness of treatment. Accurate monitoring of RR helps healthcare professionals recognise critical conditions early and improve patient outcomes.